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OPEN INNOVATION CHALLENGE STATEMENTS: GOVTECH HACKATHON – 2026

The Department of Sport, Arts and Culture (DSAC)

Problem area: Public Entities Reporting System Challenge Statement:

The Department of Sport, Arts and Culture has 26 Public Entities as well as six Non-Profit Organizations (NPOs) that receive funding from the department. The Public Entities (PEs) as well as the NPOs **must report to the department regarding the agreed targets as well as accountability of the funds received**. The lack of a digital system to track the allocation and usage of the funds as well reporting to the DSAC on their service delivery obligations to the South African citizens affects public sentiment around services rendered by these institutions.

The public entities often misses reporting deadlines due to manual reporting via email while the department struggles with analysis of the different reports as the process is still manual. The DSAC seeks an innovative solution using emerging technologies to address these challenges to provide management information at the click of a button. Participants are challenged to develop an a solution that will enable both the public entities (as subsidiaries) and the DSAC as a (holding company) to monitor performance and reporting of set targets. The solution should provide a dashboard on agreed key performance indicators.

Functional Requirements

The solution should incorporate emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence (AI), predictive analytics and intelligent automation to move beyond traditional reporting and provide proactive, datadriven insights. The technology should enable DSAC to identify emerging performance risks, predict potential delays or missed targets, and support management in making informed decisions before issues escalate.

a) **Analytics Module:** the solution should utilise predictive analytics to display a dashboard of the various public entities that should provide Trends and Patterns for each Public Entity e.g audit findings, year-on-year comparisons. The digital solution should have a clear dashboard that indicates annual targets that are in progress, not started, deadline missed and also provide statistics on staff demographics, job creation by each public entity

b) **Early Warning Functionality:** the digital solution should demonstrate intelligent, risk-based alerts that use available reporting and historical information to identify potential delays or nonperformance before deadlines are missed. Include a functionality to provide Notifications on regulatory due dates, closing dates for reports and a countdown broken down as 30 days/15 days/hourly for due reports

c) **Document Repository:** the solution should have a repository for all public entities to upload their strategic plans, Annual Performance Plans, Operational Plans and Annual Reports, Quarterly

Reports and Financials for reviews by the DSAC

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d) **Workspaces for Public Entities:** the digital solution should provide for workspaces for the public entities which seamlessly integrate with Microsoft Technologies, have version control of documents triggered at save/upload, the ability to allow comments and have comments visible on screen in real time, allow for setting of specific tasks internally and externally (up or down in the operations process), have solution to indicate approval on receipt of upload, be able to have full functionality in mobile devices and allow for mobile working environment

e) **Security and Privacy:** Demonstrate how information will be secured and align with South African cybersecurity and privacy principles.

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Department of Higher education and Training (DHET)

Challenge Title: Khetha NCAP => Your Career Guidance Companion, On the Go

DHET's Khetha Career Development Services already offers citizens the National Career Advice Portal (NCAP), an online self-help tool available at ncap.careerhelp.org.za that provides a Subject Chooser, Career Choice and Job Fit questionnaires, and directories of careers, qualifications, and learning providers ("Where to Study" and "What to Study"). NCAP is a valuable, trusted resource, but it exists today only as a desktop-oriented website, which limits its reach among the mobile-first youth who make up many of South Africa's internet users.

How might we take the proven content and tools of NCAP and reimagine them as a native mobile app to become convenient, engaging, intelligent and accessible on the devices citizens already carry, so that career guidance is always within reach rather than a website citizens must remember to visit?

Participants are challenged to design and build an NCAP mobile app, using the existing NCAP website () as the reference for scope and content, that carries its core <https://ncap.careerhelp.org.za/functionality> onto mobile while leveraging Artificial Intelligence and other appropriate emerging technologies to deliver a more personalised, intelligent and engaging career guidance experience.

The solution must go beyond simply reproducing the existing NCAP website on a smaller screen. Participants must demonstrate how emerging technologies can improve the way citizens discover, understand and navigate career, education and employment opportunities, while supporting personalisation, offline or low-bandwidth access, accessibility and engagement regardless of a user's geographic location, socio-economic circumstances or level of digital literacy.

Mandatory Requirements:

- **NCAP Reference Alignment:** The app must be built with direct reference to the existing National Career Advice Portal (<https://ncap.careerhelp.org.za/>), carrying over its core content areas and information architecture so that current NCAP users recognise and can transition to the app.
- **Subject Chooser:** Reproduce and improve on NCAP's Subject Chooser tool, helping learners select the right subjects for their intended career and study pathway.
- **Career Choice and Job Fit Questionnaires:** Bring NCAP's Career Choice and Job Fit self-assessment questionnaires onto mobile, with a simplified, app-native experience that guides users to personalised career suggestions.
- **Careers, Qualifications and Providers Directories:** Give mobile access to NCAP's careers (occupations), "What to Study" (qualifications) and "Where to Study" (learning providers) directories, with search and filtering suitable for a smaller screen.
- **Personalised Career Journey:** The app should remember a user's questionnaire results and interactions, building a personal profile that guides them from subject and career exploration through to relevant study and employment options.
- **Inclusivity Focus:** Designs must actively support rural and underserved communities, citizens with limited digital literacy or connectivity, and persons living with disabilities. For example, through offline or low-bandwidth access, multilingual support, and accessible interface design, consistent with NCAP's own accessibility considerations.

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- Engagement and Notifications: Solutions should use mobile-native capabilities such as push notifications, reminders and saved favourites to keep citizens engaged with their career journey in ways that a traditional website cannot.
- Careers Advice Directory and Contact Access: Provide easy in-app access to NCAP's careers advice directory, events and Khetha contact channels, so users can reach a human career practitioner when they need to.

Advantageous Functionality:

- Secure Digital Identity and Integration: Solutions must demonstrate secure authentication, consent management and API-based interoperability with NCAP and other relevant DHET/Khetha systems, avoiding duplicate or conflicting data.
- Data Security and Privacy: Solutions should follow best practices in safeguarding citizen information, ensuring transparency, consent management and cybersecurity throughout.

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Department of Statistics South Africa (STATS-SA)

Challenge Title: AI-Enabled Assistant for Public and Media Information Queries

Stats SA produces and disseminates official statistics that support informed decision-making and public awareness. The organisation receives a high volume of public and media queries, making the process of preparing relevant responses time-intensive. It requires the review of large volumes of statistical data, publications and organisational information to prepare accurate, timely and clearly referenced responses based on information publicly published by Stats SA. Some queries are also recurring, yet responding to them may still require Stats SA communication officials to search multiple publications and data sources to identify relevant and authoritative information. This can delay responses, increase the administrative workload of staff and heighten the risk of reliance on information that is outdated, incomplete or not officially validated.

This presents an opportunity to explore how Artificial Intelligence (AI) can assist with information retrieval, provide accurate, timely and clearly referenced responses, and support the drafting responses tailored to sensitive, complex and media queries, while maintaining human oversight, accuracy and governance. It also highlights the need for a central, trusted knowledge base where approved answers and reference material can be stored and reused.

Mandatory and Optional (though Advantageous) Design and Capability Requirements

The solution should address the identified business challenge through the following mandatory design requirements, mandatory functional capabilities and optional but advantageous capabilities

Mandatory Design requirements

- **Open Architecture and Sustainability**

Should utilise open-source components and be designed for integration with the Stats SA website as a public-facing self-service capability, supporting transparency, affordability, adaptability and long-term sustainability.

- **Web Integration and Deployment**

Must be a web-based solution capable of integration with the existing Stats SA digital environment through appropriate interfaces, such as web applications, widgets, chat interfaces, APIs or similar mechanisms.

- **Trusted Responses and Source Transparency**

Must avoid unsupported or speculative answers and clearly distinguish between official information and AI-generated wording.

- **Responsible AI and Governance**

Must support responsible AI principles, including transparency, accountability, data protection and human oversight.

- **Data Security and Privacy**

Must demonstrate appropriate security, privacy and access-control measures to protect organisational information, including role-based access, secure handling of approved information sources and data protection measures.

Mandatory Functional Capabilities

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Public Self-Service Search Assistant The solution should enable members of the public (which may include students, researchers and other stakeholders) to submit natural language queries and receive accurate, concise, plain-language responses generated automatically only from approved Stats SA information sources.

The solution should search approved data sources, retrieve relevant content, and use this information to respond directly to public queries where the information requested is factual, publicly available and supported by approved sources. Responses should include references to the reports, publications, datasets or supporting information used to formulate the response, including document titles and links where available, to support verification, plausibility assessment and further reading.

Queries that cannot be answered with sufficient confidence, or that are complex, sensitive, ambiguous, or require judgement, interpretation, reputational consideration or formal organisational approval, should be escalated with a clearly referenced draft response for review by a Stats SA communications official.

The solution should enable journalists, media houses and other communication stakeholders to submit media-related queries for processing and review.

The solution should not automatically issue responses to media queries. Instead, it should analyse the query, retrieve relevant information from approved organisational knowledge sources, publications and historical communications, and generate a structured, clearly referenced draft response for review and approval by an authorised Stats SA communications official.

Where approved sources do not provide sufficient information or references, the solution should flag the information gap and refrain from generating unsupported content.

The solution should maintain a trusted knowledge management environment that ensures all responses are grounded in approved organisational knowledge and that only trusted and authorised information is used when responding to public and media queries.

- **Media Query Escalation and Draft Response Generation**

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The solution should not automatically issue responses to media queries. Instead, it should analyse the query, retrieve relevant information from approved organisational knowledge sources, publications and historical communications, and generate a structured, clearly referenced draft response for review and approval by an authorised Stats SA communications official.

Where approved sources do not provide sufficient information or references, the solution should flag the information gap and refrain from generating unsupported content.

- **Human-in-the-Loop Review and Approval.**

Human oversight must remain central to the solution. Responses to complex, sensitive, ambiguous, media-related or low-confidence queries must be reviewed and approved by authorised Stats SA communication officials before use or publication. Final editorial responsibility remains with authorised human users.

- **Accuracy and Source Grounding**

The solution should prioritise accuracy and minimise the risk of misinformation, hallucinations or unsupported content.

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AI-generated responses and drafts should be grounded in approved source documents and enable users to verify the origin of information, supporting evidence and factual claims. Participants are encouraged to demonstrate practical mechanisms for improving trust, transparency and factual accuracy.

- **Organisational Knowledge and Communication Guidelines**

The solution should maintain a trusted knowledge management environment that ensures all responses are grounded in approved organisational knowledge and that only trusted and authorised information is used when responding to public and media queries.

The solution should enable the AI assistant to operate in accordance with approved communication guidelines, terminology, writing styles, branding requirements and organisational messaging standards, to promote consistency, accuracy and alignment with organisational standards.

Participants should consider how this organisational knowledge, communication guidance and standards can be securely managed, maintained and updated over time.

- **Communication Memory and Response Reuse**

The solution should maintain an approved communication knowledge repository containing media responses, historical press releases, official statements, FAQs and other approved organisational messaging.

The repository should be searchable by authorised users and leveraged by the AI assistant when generating media responses or communication drafts or related content.

Where similar or related queries have previously been addressed, the solution should identify and recommend relevant approved responses for reuse or adaptation, supporting consistency, reducing response times and minimising the risk of conflicting organisational positions across different communications.

- **Optional but Advantageous Capabilities**

The following capabilities are optional and are intended to encourage innovation beyond the minimum requirements. Solutions that demonstrate one or more of these capabilities may be viewed favourably during evaluation.

- **Intelligent Document and Content Analysis**

The solution should enable authorised users to analyse approved reports, statistical releases, research publications and other official content to identify key findings, statistics, trends, insights and contextual information relevant to communication activities such as media and press communications.

The solution should assist users in converting complex or technical information into clear, understandable communication while preserving the meaning and accuracy of the source material.

- **Communication Support Assistant**

The solution should support Stats SA communication officials by identifying relevant source material, summarising supporting evidence, highlighting previous approved responses, and suggesting approved organisational language and terminology.

- **AI-Assisted Press and Media Release Generation**

The solution should enable users to generate draft media statements, press releases, media advisories, public announcements, executive summaries, FAQs and other communication products, based on approved source information.

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Users should be able to select the desired communication format, audience and level of detail before generating a draft. All AI-generated content should be clearly presented as a draft requiring human review and approval.

- **Audience and Channel Adaptation**

The solution should enable users to adapt approved information for different audiences and communication channels, including media organisations, the public, government stakeholders, social media and digital communication platforms, while maintaining consistency with approved source information.

- **Multilingual and Inclusive Communication**

Participants are encouraged to explore multilingual capabilities that can assist Stats SA communication officials in preparing or adapting content for different language audiences, subject to appropriate human review before publication.

- **Integration and Interoperability**

The solution should demonstrate how it could integrate with existing government systems and communication environments, including document management systems, knowledge repositories, content management platforms, internal communication systems and approved government digital platforms.

Participants are encouraged to consider API-based interoperability, scalability and future integration requirements.

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